

Q. Do you think everything should be open sourced?

A. In specific situations, things should be open sourced, especially if a project is funded by taxpayers' money. The source should be open if it's financed by the public, allowing taxpayers access. Even if not everyone can use it directly, provisions should enable inspection and use for the greater good. However, in some sectors, particularly those involving defence, the decision to go open source needs careful consideration. Projects related to the military or sensitive fields might require more closed approaches. In such cases, the benefits of openness need balancing against potential risks and security concerns.

Q. What about open sourcing in critical systems? Is it questionable?

A. No, it's not questionable for critical systems; ideally, critical infrastructure should be open source. Openness allows greater visibility into software, facilitating quicker bug identification and fixes. Open sourcing enhances security and reliability through scrutiny and improvement by a large developer community, ensuring no hidden vulnerabilities and enabling timely updates. However, in specific areas like military services, maintaining closed source may be justified for defence reasons. Apart from such cases, most areas, especially critical infrastructure, benefit significantly from being open source. Much critical infrastructure, including Linux server systems, follows this approach for transparency, security, and community-driven oversight, crucial for robust systems.

Q. How have open source projects impacted cost savings in a company?

A. One of the most significant cost savings for a company engaged with an open source product is the ability

to leverage innovations from outside their immediate corporate circle. People who examine the software or code, might think of a new angle for a feature or improvement, which is then contributed back to the project. This external contribution allows a company to integrate new features into their product and offer them to their customers. The key benefit here is innovation. By leveraging open source, a company can reduce development costs, save time, and innovate in a much shorter cycle, making it one of the most tangible benefits of engaging with open source projects.

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Q. How does one determine which licence sits well with a particular open source software?

A. The choice of licence depends on the business model and the intended use of the software. Each licence has its own terms and conditions, catering to different requirements and objectives. If you have a specific licensing agreement in mind, it's crucial to thoroughly understand the nuances of that licence, as there are many variations, and each serves a different purpose. At The Document Foundation, we use Mozilla and GNU General Public Licence (GPL) and cannot opt for some different licence without violating our own statutes.

Q. As an industry expert, how would you advise someone on choosing licences?

A. Understanding the mindset behind open source is crucial for

selecting an appropriate licence. The less open the source, the tougher the licence. Many arguments in favour of open source align with business practices. Most queries about open source centre around adapting business models within this framework. Despite the variety of licences available, numerous businesses thrive under strict, Open Source Initiative (OSI)-approved licences by delivering added value rather than relying solely on licensing fees for revenue. The Document Foundation adds value to finance activities without compromising dedication to the open source ethos.

When advising on licence selection, consider the primary revenue generation goal. I advocate a business model that emphasises authenticity and open source commitment. Choose a licence that fully supports open source ideals, to avoid dilution and move towards a model that upholds transparency and the core values of open source.

Q. What do you mean by ‘the less open the source, the tougher the licence is’?

A. What I mean is that the closer you adhere to the Four Freedoms of open source – the freedom to run, study, distribute, and modify the software – the more aligned with open source principles you are. If your licence restricts any of these Four Freedoms, you are moving away from the core ethos of open source. Essentially, the more open-minded you are towards these freedoms, the more open your licence is. This has interesting implications for organisations, especially in terms of cost savings. The difference lies between an organisation like TDF, which focuses on public good, and commercial companies. TDF, for instance, doesn't aim to earn profits but relies on donations and similar forms of support. In contrast, commercial entities might approach open source differently, balancing the principles of open source with their business models.